Tracing a company's digital footprint from photos and a leaked document

ANALYST
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ROLE
Threat Intel · OSINT

ENVIRONMENT
Training lab

HANDLING
Sanitised, no flags

SUMMARY

Working on a fictional company, I traced what could be learned from its shared photos and a leaked office document, and how small metadata leaks chain together into an identity.

SCOPE

Images and one .odt document provided by the lab, plus public web sources. The target company is fictional.

METHOD

1. Extracted EXIF data with ExifTool, converted GPS coordinates from DMS to decimal and placed them on a map.
2. Identified a landmark using reverse image search and text visible in the image.
3. Opened the .odt as a ZIP archive and read meta.xml for author and custom fields.
4. Pivoted the internal username found in the metadata to public social accounts.

FINDINGS

- Photo metadata exposed a precise location.
- Document metadata exposed an internal username that linked to a public account.
- Specific locations and usernames are left out so the room is not spoiled.

RECOMMENDATIONS

- Strip EXIF data from images before they are published.
- Clean document metadata (author, custom properties) before sharing files externally.
- Keep work and personal usernames separate, and cover this in awareness training.
- Run periodic OSINT checks on the organisation's own footprint.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR THE ROLE

Each leak looked harmless on its own. Chained together they identified a person, so defenders should run the same pivots on themselves before an attacker does.